The BJP also does not have a Brahmin CM in the Hindi heartland—both Yogi Adityanath in Uttar Pradesh and Pushkar Singh Dhami in Uttarakhand are Rajputs. The Rajputs have always voted the BJP in Rajasthan, the Brahmin vote is split between the Congress and BJP. By appointing a Brahmin CM now, the BJP hopes to attract the entire vote of the community.

Sharma fit the bill perfectly, and not just for the surprise quotient his name carried. Unassuming by nature, with humility and committed party work being his hallmarks, he is also in the good books of the parent Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS). Displaying a complete lack of obsession with power and shunning the limelight, Sharma's relative anonymity outside the office also worked in his favour.





THE DEPUTIES
Diya Kumari;
Prem Chand Bairwa

TICKING ALL THE BOXES

In hindsight, all signs pointed to the fact that Sharma was destined to play a significant role. The ticket distribution itself should have been one indication. The BJP chose to retain most of the sitting MLAs in safe seats. One notable exception was the 52-year-old Rajsamand MP Diya Kumari, who replaced Narpat Singh Rajvi, a former minister, four-time MLA and son-in-law of the late Bhairon Singh Shekhawat, in Vidyadhar Nagar. Sharma was the second, from Sanganer. Both seats, in the Jaipur zone, are the epitome of 'safe' for saffron. Sharma's candidature, though, went completely unnoticed by virtue of the significance of the man he was replacing—Ashok Lahoti. In 2018, Lahoti had been the BJP's chosen instrument to demonstrate its clout in Sanganer, making even a formidable rival like Ghanshyam Tiwari forfeit his deposit. Ironically, Tiwari is now a BJP Rajya Sabha MP and Lahoti has had to pay a high price for allegedly exposing corruption by a BJP mayor and a top RSS functionary in a sting operation.

This time Sanganer, home of Jaipur's famous block-printing tradition, was to leave a bigger impress on Rajasthan politics. But outside the power circle, no one knew, not even Raje. And on December 12, the supense of a lottery hung in the air as Union defence minister Rajnath Singh, the central observer, handed Raje a slip on stage and asked her to read out the name scribbled on it. That cancelled her out. And when Sharma's name was spoken, it demolished the hopes of a whole gallery of other contenders. Diya Kumari had stood a good chance, but then she would have cemented the perception of the BJP replacing one royal with another. Diya is from the Jaipur house and Raje from the Dholpur-Scindia line. Diya has been appointed deputy CM instead, restoring a measure of caste equilibrium in the state, assuaging Rajput sentiment.

Two other leaders fit the BJP's scheme of things but did not make it to the top post. Vasudev Devnani, 74, was overlooked because of his age and the fact that his Sindhi caste has limited political influence. A two-time minister of state in the Raje government, he was given the post of Speaker as consolation prize. There was also the 54-year-old Prem Chand Bairwa, who has been made a second deputy CM owing to his Dalit background. All three leaders are also Sangh favourites despite their past associations with Raje. They are no longer in her political circle, though, which strengthened their case for a place in the current anti-Raje administration.

Sharma has actively contributed to the BJP and its front organisations for the past 38 years even though he strayed in 2003. That year, he took the unique political step of contesting as an Independent from the Nadbai constituency. He fought on a ticket given by the Samajai Nyay Manch, which was emerging as a third front advocating against OBC reservations for Jats and pushing for special quota for the economically weak among the privileged castes. However, like many of the forum's candidates,

BHAJAN LAL SHARMA, 56

PERSONAL BACKGROUND: Born in a village in Bharatpur district to a farmer couple; Brahmin by caste

EDUCATION: MA in Political Science (non-collegiate) from Rajasthan University

FAMILY: Married to Geeta Sharma; has two sons—Ashish is preparing for civil services and Kunal has done his MBBS

POSTS HELD: Twice elected sarpanch, once as a member of panchayat samiti

POLITICAL TRAINING: After early stints with ABVP and BJYM, became BJP district president and later state vice president. Has been general secretary since 2016. Was jailed during the Kashmir March in 1990 and the Ram Temple movement

WORK STYLE: Listens to everyone but once he takes a decision, he is stubbornly final. Strongly determined, finishes every task he's given